

Ask the machine what it costs

20 minutes boot camp, 15 minutes deep dive

You have just watched a context window fill and heard that tokens are how you pay for it. Now ask the machine itself. Two questions, four places to ask them, and the answers do not agree. That disagreement is the lesson.

BEFORE YOU START

- The Claude desktop app open and signed in. You checked this in the introduction.
- Claude Code installed, which you also did in the introduction. You will use it from the Code screen inside the desktop app.
- Access to Claude Design. If Design is missing from the sidebar, ask.

FINDING YOUR WAY AROUND

One window. Chat and Cowork are a toggle inside the message box. Code is the angle-bracket button at the top of the sidebar, next to the chat icon. Design is an entry in the sidebar. New, at the top of the sidebar, starts a fresh conversation wherever you are. Each step below has a picture with the thing to click boxed in red.

THE TWO QUESTIONS

Type them exactly. Same words every time, so the only thing that changes is where you ask.

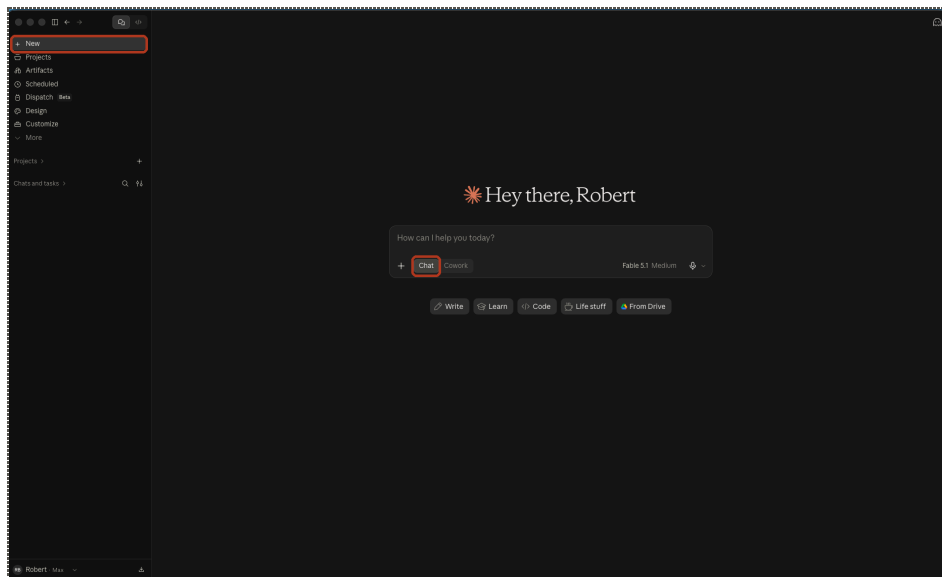
Question 1

```
How much context does your system prompt and pre-loaded files use?
```

Question 2

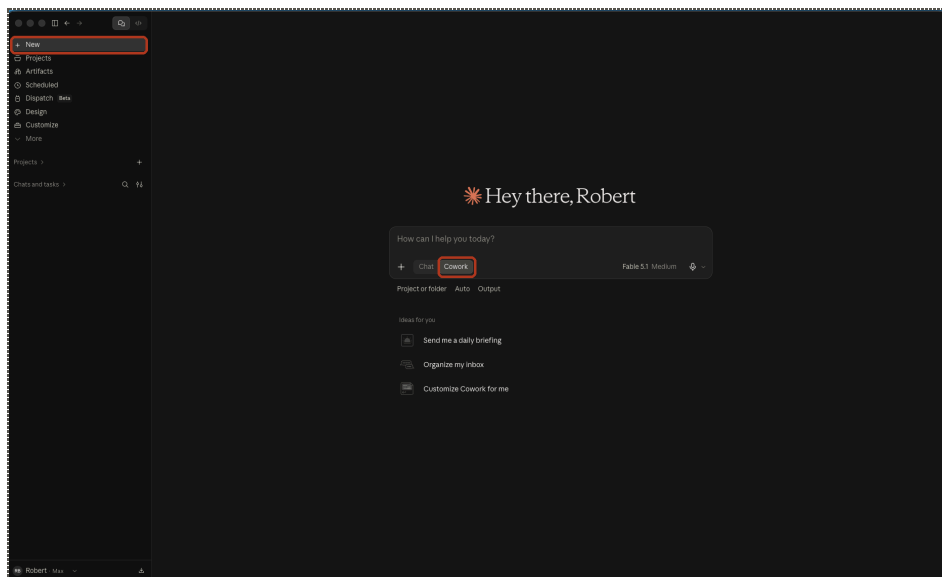
```
How many tokens did this use? And how much would this have cost if I was using the API?
```

STEP 1: CHAT



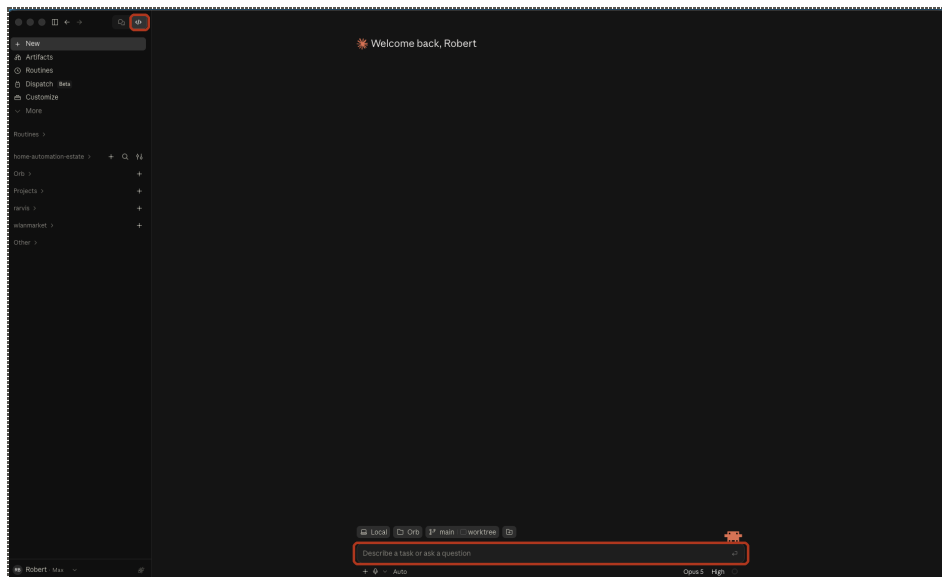
Click New. In the message box, make sure Chat is the selected half of the toggle. Ask question 1, then question 2. Notice whether it gave you a number, a range, or a shrug, and whether it said where the number came from.

STEP 2: COWORK



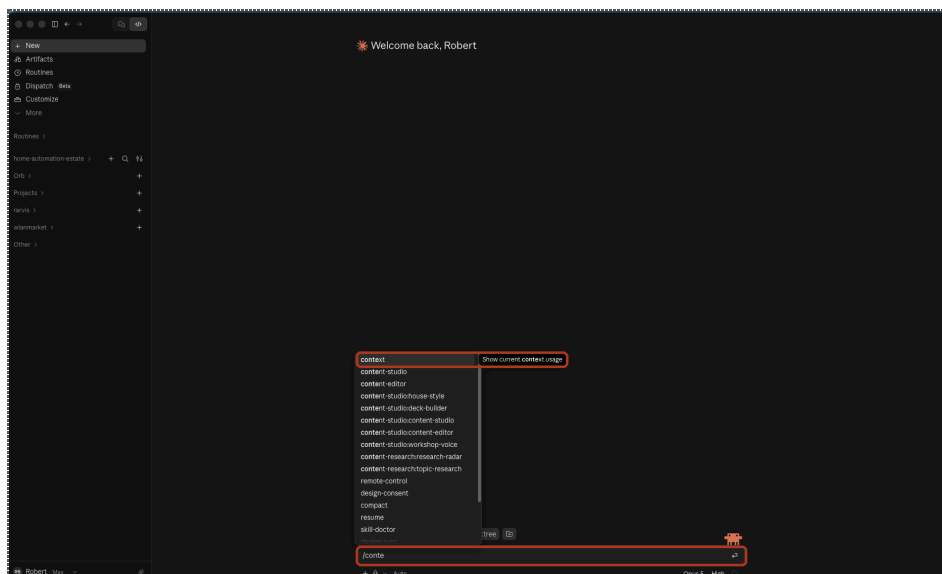
Click New again, and this time click Cowork in the toggle. Same two questions, same order. Compare the answers with Chat's.

STEP 3: CODE



Click the angle-bracket button at the top of the sidebar. The Code screen opens with a prompt line at the bottom. Before asking anything, type this into it:

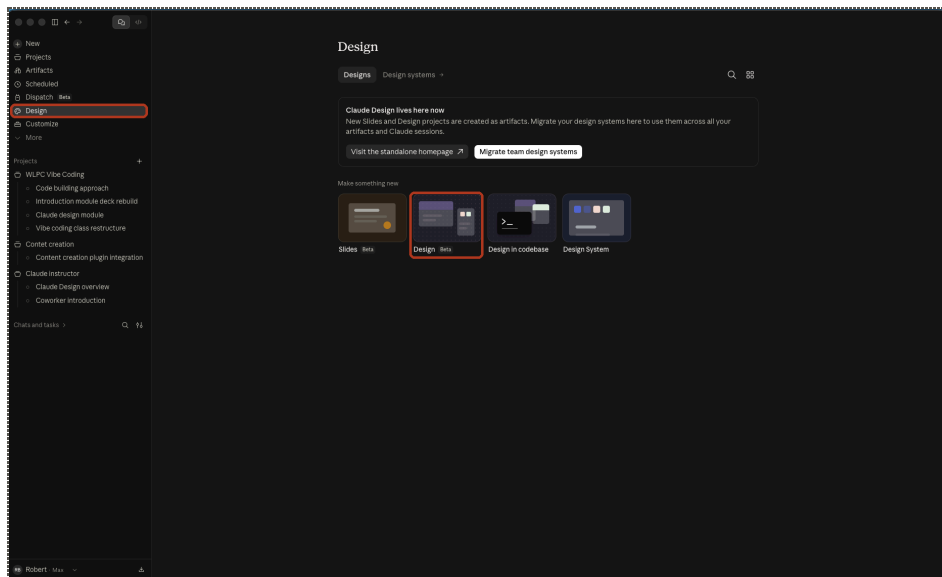
```
/context
```



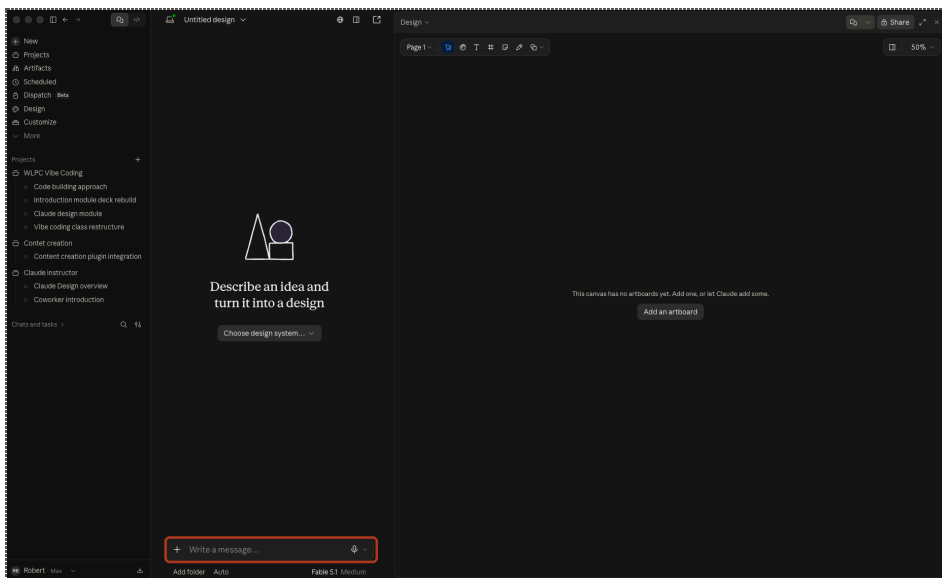
As you type, a popup lists the commands and shows "context: Show current context usage". Press return. Look at the total it shows and the three biggest categories. This is the one place in the lab where the number is measured rather than guessed.

Now ask question 2 only, since /context has already answered question 1 better than the model can.

STEP 4: DESIGN



Click Design in the sidebar, then the Design tile under "Make something new". A blank design opens with its own message box on the left.



Ask both questions there.

YOUR TABLE, IF YOU WANT ONE

	CHAT	COWORK	CODE	DESIGN
Q1: context used before you typed				
Q2: tokens this used				
Q2: cost on the API				
Model it said it was				

You're done when you've asked in all four places. If a surface said it can't tell, that is an answer. Bring what you found back to the room.